CHAPTER 4

THE RISE OF MILITANCY IN PAKISTAN AFTER 2001

THE FOURTH PHASE

This phase started at the end of 2001 when a large number of Taliban and Al Qaeda fighters, pressed by the US Operations 'Enduring Freedom' and 'Anaconda', sneaked into Pakistan through the porous Pak-Afghan border. The American forces were not deployed around the Tora Bora Mountains in Afghanistan because the US Air Force planes relentlessly dropped heavy bombs there to kill Osama bin Laden and his several hundred men. Then US Secretary of Defence Donald Rumsfeld and General Tommy Frank had taken this decision to avoid backlash from the locals over the presence of American forces in that area (Report to Members of the Committee on Foreign Relations United States Senate, 2009). This excuse, however, did not seem plausible, rather Rumsfeld was probably afraid of US troop losses.

On the contrary, the Pakistani militias and Frontier Constabulary were not well equipped to plug the rugged mountainous routes from Tora Bora inside Pakistan. Resultantly, about 1,000 Al Qaeda men entered Pakistan (Report to Members of the Committee on Foreign Relations United States Senate, 2009). Small US Delta Force comprising 40 odd men could do little. Soon, FATA became a fertile base for the Al Qaeda, Afghan Taliban and their local sympathisers, who were to become a formidable force titled Tehreek-e-Taliban Pakistan (TTP). These local militants rapidly gained enough strength to carry out operations in FATA, NWFP (KP) and across Pakistan, as